

Foundations of Computer Science

CSCI 1310 – Section 801

Department of Computer Science & Engineering

Summer 2026

Instructor Information

Instructor: Prof. Jordan K. Vasquez

Email: jkvasquez@wcu.edu

Office Location: Tech Innovation Center 340

Office Hours: TWTh 1:00pm – 3:00pm or by appointment

Preferred Method of Contact: jkvasquez@wcu.edu or Campus LMS Inbox

When emailing, please include your course section number or class meeting time. My goal is to respond to all student communications within 24–48 hours on weekdays.

Teaching Assistant(s)

Chloe Wu | Lab & Grading TA | cwu@wcu.edu

Nathan Obi | Tutoring TA | nobi@wcu.edu

Course Details

Meeting Days/Times/Locations

Start Date	End Date	Location	Meeting Day	Start Time	End Time
05/27/2026	09/15/2026	TIC 0112	MWF	3:00 PM	3:50 PM
05/27/2026	09/15/2026	TIC LAB 0050	Th	3:00 PM	4:50 PM

Credit Hours: 3.00

Course Description

Introduction to the fundamental concepts of computer science and programming. Topics include problem-solving strategies, algorithm design, data types, control structures, functions, recursion, basic data structures, and computational thinking. Programming is done in Python. No prior programming experience required.

Required Texts and Materials

Textbook: Introduction to Computation and Programming Using Python

ISBN: 9780262542364

Authors: Guttag, John V.

Publisher: MIT Press

Edition: 3rd

Additional Required Materials

- Python 3.11+ (free download at python.org)
- VS Code IDE (free download)
- Google Colab (free, browser-based alternative)

Course Learning Outcomes

Upon successful completion of this course, students will be able to:

1. CLO 1: Write syntactically correct Python programs that solve clearly defined problems
2. CLO 2: Apply algorithmic thinking to decompose problems into logical steps
3. CLO 3: Use control structures (conditionals, loops) and functions appropriately
4. CLO 4: Implement and manipulate basic data structures including lists and dictionaries
5. CLO 5: Debug and test programs systematically using print statements and test cases
6. CLO 6: Explain the social and ethical implications of computing technology

Grading Policies & Grading Scale

Grade Breakdown

Activity	Weight	Details
Lab Assignments	20%	Weekly labs in Python; completed in lab session; 1 drop allowed
Programming Homework	20%	Biweekly take-home programs; 3 attempts; lowest 1 dropped
Midterm Exam 1	15%	Written + coding; Weeks 1–4; June 24, 2026
Midterm Exam 2	15%	Written + coding; Weeks 5–8; July 22, 2026
Midterm Exam 3	10%	Written + coding; Weeks 9–11; August 19, 2026
Final Project	10%	Solo or pair programming project; demo Sep 9; report due Sep 9
Final Exam	10%	Comprehensive; September 11, 2026; 3:00 PM – 5:00 PM
Total	100%	

Grading Scale

A	A-	B+	B	B-	C+	C	C-	D+	D	D-	F
100–93	92–90	89–87	86–83	82–80	79–77	76–73	72–70	69–67	66–63	62–60	59–00

NOTE: Final grades are recorded as posted. No grade changes will be made after final grades are submitted.

Late Work Policy

- Late work is penalized 10% per day of delay.
- Assignments more than 5 days late will not be accepted.
- Lab/in-class work cannot be made up without a documented, university-approved excuse.

Important Exam Dates

Assessment	Date / Details
Midterm Exam 1	Written + coding; Weeks 1–4; June 24, 2026
Midterm Exam 2	Written + coding; Weeks 5–8; July 22, 2026
Midterm Exam 3	Written + coding; Weeks 9–11; August 19, 2026
Final Exam	Comprehensive; September 11, 2026; 3:00 PM – 5:00 PM

Course Schedule

Note: This schedule is subject to change. Any modifications will be announced via the LMS and/or email.

Week / Dates	Topic(s)	Assignments / Notes
Week 1 (May 27–30)	Intro to CS; Python Setup; Variables	Lab 1: Hello World; HW 1 assigned
Week 2 (Jun 1–6)	Data Types; Expressions; Input/Output	Lab 2: Calculator Programs; HW 1 due Jun 5
Week 3 (Jun 8–13)	Conditionals: if/elif/else	Lab 3: Decision Programs; HW 2 assigned
Week 4 (Jun 15–20)	Loops: while and for	Lab 4: Loop Exercises; HW 2 due Jun 19
Week 5 (Jun 22–27)	EXAM 1 – Jun 24 Functions & Scope	Lab 5: Function Writing; HW 3 assigned
Week 6 (Jun 29–Jul 4)	Strings & String Methods	Lab 6: String Manipulation (No lab Jul 4)
Week 7 (Jul 6–11)	Lists & List Operations	Lab 7: List Programs; HW 3 due Jul 10; HW 4 assigned
Week 8 (Jul 13–18)	Dictionaries & Tuples	Lab 8: Data Structure Practice; HW 4 due Jul 17
Week 9 (Jul 20–25)	EXAM 2 – Jul 22 File I/O	Lab 9: File Reading & Writing; HW 5 assigned
Week 10 (Jul 27–Aug 1)	Recursion I	Lab 10: Recursive Functions; HW 5 due Jul 31

Week / Dates	Topic(s)	Assignments / Notes
Week 11 (Aug 3–8)	Recursion II; Sorting Algorithms	Lab 11: Sorting Practice; HW 6 assigned
Week 12 (Aug 10–15)	EXAM 3 – Aug 19 Searching; Complexity Intro	Lab 12: Algorithm Analysis; HW 6 due Aug 14
Week 13 (Aug 17–22)	Object-Oriented Programming I	Lab 13: Classes & Objects; Final Project assigned
Week 14 (Aug 24–29)	Object-Oriented Programming II	Lab 14: OOP Practice
Week 15 (Sep 1–5)	Ethics in Computing; Review	Final Project due Sep 9
Final Exam	September 11, 2026 3:00 PM – 5:00 PM	Comprehensive – All Weeks

Course Policies

- All programming assignments must run without errors to receive full credit.
- Late homework: 10% penalty per day, max 50%; labs cannot be submitted late.
- Code plagiarism (copying from classmates or the internet) will result in a zero and academic integrity report.
- Use of Generative AI to write code is NOT permitted; you must write and understand all code yourself.
- Students are encouraged to use the tutoring TA for help during office hours before submitting.
- Pair programming is allowed only for the Final Project unless otherwise specified.

Attendance Policy

Regular attendance is essential to success in this course. Students are expected to attend all scheduled class sessions and arrive on time. Attendance will be recorded each session.

Free Absences: Students are permitted two (2) free lecture absences and one (1) free lab absence per semester without penalty or documentation. Use these wisely.

Religious Observances: Notify the instructor in writing within the first two weeks of the semester. Arrangements for make-up work must be made in advance.

University Events: Provide official documentation from your university sponsor. Contact the instructor well in advance.

Exam Day Absences: Medical absences on exam days require documentation from a physician or the University Health Center and will be handled on a case-by-case basis.

Academic Integrity

Students are expected to maintain the highest standards of academic honesty. All submitted work must represent the student's own effort. Violations of the Academic Integrity Policy, including plagiarism, cheating, or unauthorized use of AI-generated content, will be referred to the Office of Academic Affairs and may result in a failing grade for the assignment or the course.

Generative AI Policy

The use of generative AI tools (including but not limited to ChatGPT, Google Gemini, Copilot, and DALL-E) is governed by the policy stated in the grading section above. Any violations will be treated as academic dishonesty. Students are encouraged to maintain time-stamped drafts and notes as evidence of independent work.

Disability Accommodations & Title IX

Disability Accommodations

Students who require academic accommodations must register with the Disability Resource Center (DRC) at drc.wcu.edu or by calling 828-227-2716. Once registered, students must submit an accommodation letter to the instructor at least one week before accommodations are needed. Accommodations are not retroactive.

Sexual Harassment & Title IX

All forms of sexual harassment, including sexual assault and dating violence, violate WCU policy and may violate federal law. Students may report concerns to the Title IX Coordinator at titleix@wcu.edu or 828-227-7021. Faculty are mandatory reporters.

Student Support Services

- Academic Success Center – Free tutoring and academic coaching: asc.wcu.edu
- Writing & Learning Commons – Writing support for all disciplines: writingcenter.wcu.edu
- Counseling & Psychological Services (CAPS) – Mental health support: 828-227-7469
- University Health Services – Medical and wellness support: 828-227-7640
- Dean of Students Office – Emergency support and student advocacy: 828-227-7234

Note: This syllabus is subject to change. The instructor reserves the right to modify the course schedule, assignments, and policies. Changes will be announced promptly via the LMS.